Plato's philosophy of a "world soul" was actually a reference to the Holy Spirit; that through logic, any man could grasp the essence of the Trinity; that scripture was *involucrum*, inherently difficult and figurative, "fruitfully obscure" in a way that forced readers to use reason and dialectic as they wrestled with the meaning.[4]

None of this was intended to destroy the faith. Like Anselm, Peter Abelard believed that truth would withstand Aristotle's methods. But this alarmed his more traditionally minded brethren. When they accused him of endangering the doctrines of the Church, he offered to explain why his conclusions were true: "We take no account of rational explanation," one opponent retorted, "nor of your interpretation in such matters; we recognize only the words of authority."[5]



7.1 Peter Abelard's France

In 1121, a church council at Soissons, attended by a papal legate, ordered Abelard to throw his *Theologia* into the fire. He obeyed, but he did not change his views on the value of reason and logic. For the next twenty years, Abelard wrote and taught, defending his orthodoxy even while he criticized